

CHANTING, A NEW MANTRA

Mamata Banerjee offers prayers during the ISKCON rath yatra in Kolkata; below, Bengal BJP chief Sukanta Majumdar (2nd from left) and others extend an invite to the PM to the Gita recital, Nov. 17



Photographs by ANI

Konthe Gitapaath (Gita recital by a lakh voices). It is being organised by the Sanatan Sanskriti Sangsad, a year-old consortium of monks, and is being supported by the BJP. Kartik Maharaj, the Sangsad president, is a member of the Bharat Sevasram Sangha, a religious and charitable organisation founded in 1917 in Bengal. "Modiji has an old connection with Bharat Sevashram, from the time he was an RSS pracharak in Gujarat," says Maharaj. On November 17, Bengal BJP chief Sukanta Majumdar had accompanied Maharaj and other monks to New Delhi, when the PM was invited to the event. President Droupadi Murmu is also invited, but has not confirmed her presence.

While Majumdar and Maharaj say the event is apolitical and that MPs and MLAs on all sides and even Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee have been invited to it, the BJP's backing and Modi's presence lend it a fairly unambiguous colour. One BJP source has no qualms admitting as much. "On December 24, one lakh people will recite from the Bhagavad Gita in Modiji's presence. A month later, he will inaugurate the Ram temple in Ayodhya. It will build like a crescendo just before the polls."

According to sources, leader of the Opposition and BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari had the idea of inviting Modi to the event. "Suvendu *babu* advised us to write to Modiji. The RSS is also helping us," says Maharaj. The BJP is arranging five trains from different parts of the state to ferry people to the event. It will be mounted on a grand scale—1,000 monks will read from the Gita, 5,000 women will join them, blowing conches. A stage will seat 60 prominent invitees, including the PM.

No wonder the TMC has yet again rediscovered its empathy for Hindus and is wearing it on its sleeve. On December 10, a fortnight before the saffron jamboree unfolds in the heart of Kolkata, the 627-year-old temple of Jagannath in Mahesh reverberated with the sounds of a Gita recital by 2,000 people. The event was organised by the TMC's Serampore MP Kalyan Banerjee and attended by panchayat minister Pradip Mazumdar. While the BJP complained that none of its representatives were invited, Piyal Adhikary, secretary of the Mahesh Lord Jagannath Temple Trust, sought to explain away the event as a routine ritualistic one. But even that had an undertone favourable to the TMC. "In 2021, the CM instructed that the throne be renovated. During it, the idols had to be placed in a separate room. They have been reinstated sometime back and the Gita recital was organised as part of this event," Adhikary says. Mazumdar later refuted BJP spokesperson Samik Bhattacharya's charge that the TMC's "sudden surge in Hindutva" was a reaction to the upcoming Kolkata event.

The BJP's attempts to paint Mamata as an anti-Hindu politician engaged in 'minority appeasement' helped it win 57 per cent of Hindu votes (and 18 seats) in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls in Bengal. However, with the TMC thereafter taking special care to pander to Hindu sentiments—stipends for priests, softened stance on cow slaughter, Mamata chanting Sanskrit shlokas, invoking deities and calling herself a "Hindu girl" in rallies—it cut its losses in the 2021 assembly polls, defeating the BJP handsomely. Since then, the TMC's conspicuous Hindu outreach has spread. The 65-metre-high Jagannath temple is coming up on a 20-acre plot on the Digha seashore in East Midnapore. The cost, nearly Rs 150 crore, is being borne by the West Bengal Housing Infrastructure Development Corporation. A Vaishno Devi temple has come up in Kolkata's Behala; prominent temples, like Kalighat in Kolkata, Tarakeswar in Hooghly and Tarapeeth in Birbhum, are being renovated. 'Soft Hindutva' hasn't helped other Opposition parties much. Will the TMC fare better? ■

HIGH PRIESTS

- **PM Modi will attend a huge Gita recital event on Dec. 24 in Kolkata**
- **On Dec. 10, TMC held a similar event at a prominent temple**
- **The BJP, TMC are engaged in competitive Hindutva in Bengal**